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Historian Assaf Tareq Hader, the head of Shikla in East Jerusalem, with Hanan Amichai, Director of their art studio in Abu Tor; Melhem Bader, principal of the Ibdaa School of the Arts in Sheikh Jarrah, with two award winning Israeli musicians who teach at the school's music conservatory; Elad Schechter, Artistic Director of C.A.T.A.M.O.N Dance Group with partner Miguel; Maya Halevi, former Director of Bloomfield Science Museum and Matan Israeli, Director of Muslala; Ohad Naharin, one of the world's greatest choreographers, with leaders of his Gaga movement enterprise, including my dear friend, choreographer Saar Harari.

JERUSALEM INTERNATIONAL FELLOWS

Dear <<First Name>>,

On April 2nd I returned from five intense days in Israel. During my visit, I met with colleagues from East and West Jerusalem who had been essential partners in the 2022 Jerusalem International Fellows Residency. I wasn't there to "do business." I wanted to see them. Hug them. See how they are doing. I also spent time with friends living in Jerusalem and Tel Aviv, all of whom know someone who has been directly affected by the horrific events of October 7th.

I saw my dear friend, Fitz Haney, a major Obama supporter and former Ambassador to Costa Rica, who I had the privilege of working with when he was co-chair of the Foundation for Jewish Culture. Fitz's 22 year old son has been serving in Gaza since the war began. He has seen unspeakable horrors with no time to "process." Asher's battalion is raising money for new vests, helmets, shoes, and other equipment - and in Fitz's words "while we all are praying for a quick resolution and a lasting peace for both Gazans and Israelis - we need to be prepared...." <https://my.israelgives.org/en/fundme/890> With this escalating conflict with Iran, his words ring truer than ever.

A young Israeli who is black and lesbian feels excommunicated from her communities because she also identifies as a Zionist. Another colleague is

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as ambassadors of hostages' families is beyond me. I heard Rachel Goldberg speak at the protest at the UN calling for the release of hostages after 6 months. In spite of the severity of her own fear and exhaustion, she took time to talk about the Thai Buddhists and the African Christians still being held hostage. The ones people don't talk about. What a brave, compassionate woman.

My Palestinian friends in East Jerusalem were afraid to go out of their homes during the first months after October 7. Too dangerous to ride the light rail. Walking down the street could result in being beaten by the police, or worse. One of my colleagues serves hundreds of Palestinian teenagers who are traumatized. He is a Druze who served in the IDF many years ago (he was in intelligence.). His family's village in the north is being bombed by Hezbollah.

One friend believes that Israel must stop fighting and start a peace process at any cost. Another believes they must destroy Hamas at any cost.

What was reinforced for me: Israelis are not the government of Israel. Palestinians civilians are not all Hamas. In both cases, so-called leaders are failing their people. And there is enormous distrust on both sides.

I continue to feel like an emotional pinball. I sense the keen distress of my Israeli friends – shock, trauma, and anger at Hamas and at their own government. The people I know are demonstrating against the Israeli government, facing cannons spewing skunk water and arrest. They are especially upset by how the progressive left discounts their experience – from doubting the rape of hostages to the shout of “From the River to the Sea” – a call to destroy the State of Israel. They wonder how well educated folks do not understand the explicit goal of Hamas to destroy Israel and put their own people at risk to accomplish this task? (Yuval Bitton [I Asked Sinwar, Is It Worth 10,000 Innocent Gazans Dying? He Said, Even 100,000 Is Worth It'](#) .)

There is palpable fear. Especially since last week's attack and all manner of [cyberattacks](#). (As always, I recommend reading [Dahlia Scheindlin](#) to get FACTS and global context.) Some say that without Israel, the Jews will end up in concentration camps again. Sounds crazy. Then again, there are a few survivors still alive and more children of survivors for whom that threat is still real. The worldwide rise of anti-semitism stokes their anxiety.

My Palestinian friends are equally shocked, traumatized and fearful. And what they are seeing in Gaza and the W

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lovingly wrapped with handmade knitted and crocheted yellow “ribbons”. They reminded me of how the Japanese tenderly wrap their trees before they position a support where it is needed.

At Tel Aviv Museum’s plaza – now “Hostage Square” – searing artworks, made by artists and community members, are everywhere. One in particular – Roni Levavi’s THE TUNNEL “simulates the terrible reality into which our hostages have been thrown.” It literally concretized their terrifying experience and the fact that Hamas squandered billions of dollars in international aid to the Gazan people to build 100 miles of tunnels out of which they are waging this insane war. And then I read how Dar Jacir, a wonderful artist residency in Bethlehem, which our Fellows visited in 2022, was damaged by the IDF. WHY? More to add to my emotional rollercoaster.

The day I returned to NY was the night that the IDF killed seven aid workers in the clearly marked truck of World Central Kitchen— one of the world’s most effective NGO’s – which had communicated with and had clearance from the IDF. Gut punch. I had just read, at the urging of an Israeli friend, a piece in [Newsweek](#) about how the IDF works harder than any army to protect civilians. What was the calculus here that allowed such a terrible mistake???? For what it’s worth, the IDF investigated, took responsibility and apologized. This horrific act might have changed the course of the war – towards peace. But so much damage was done.

Rebuilding trust with someone you see as a mortal enemy is an extraordinarily difficult, seemingly impossible task. Yet it has happened in Rwanda, in Ireland, with Japan, Germany and the U.S. What were the essential steps that made a reasonably tenable peace possible? No doubt there is rancor. But there is no war. Part of the solution is the power of artists (and scientists and healthcare workers) to transcend boundaries, to build bridges and to promote healing.

I don’t know how or when the Jerusalem Cultural Residency will return but I do know people there, East and West, want international artists to come and help them reimagine their city. Stay tuned...

Since October 7th there are still 133 hostages who have not been released from Gaza (dead or alive) and over 30,000 Palestinians killed. Many of whom are women and children. Those alive are facing starvation.

I am praying for the end of this war. The return of the hostages. The restoration of health

"Remember the stranger because you were strangers..." and, per **Isaiah 58:7**, "share bread with the hungry and bring the homeless into your house." Israel is fighting powerful global forces that want it erased. And still, as terrified as we are as Jews, we can't lose our humanity.

Wishing you a safe and meaningful Passover.

- Elise

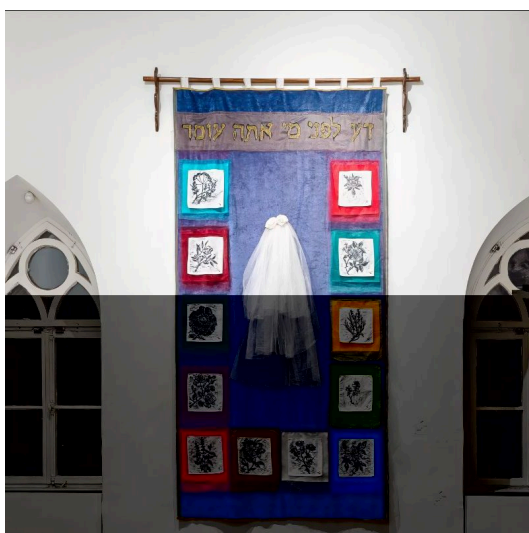
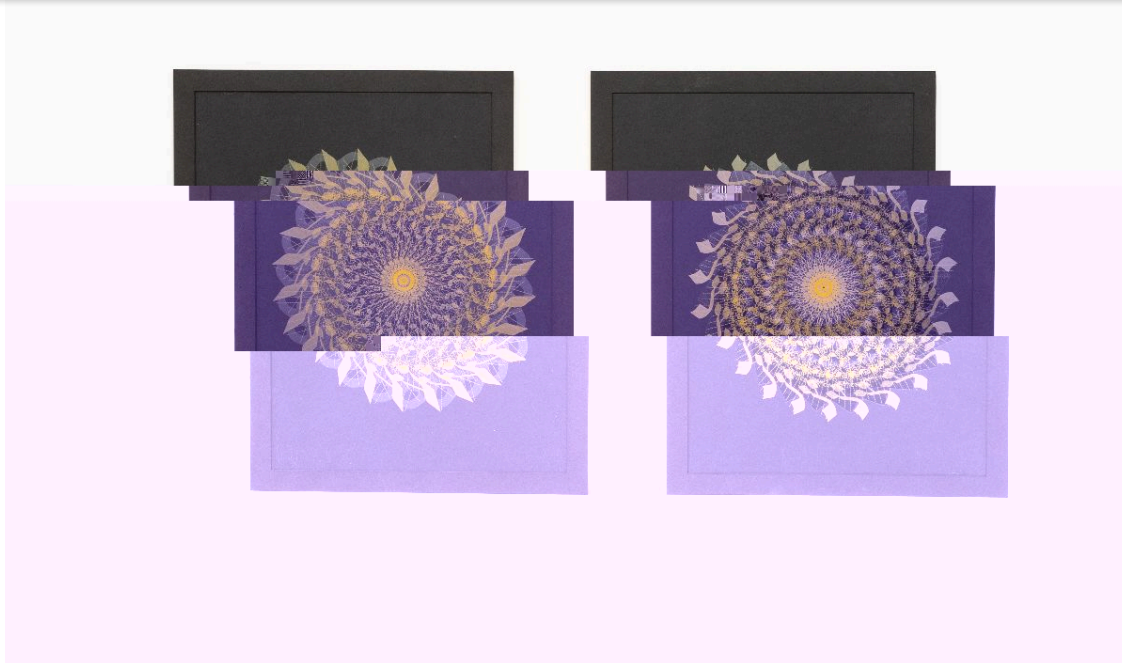


The new Ibdaa School of the Arts under construction next to the Central Library in East Jerusalem.

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One of the lovely moment's during my trip was to the Italian Jewish Museum to see curator Emily Bilski's beautiful exhibition, *THREADING*, which was part of the Jerusalem Biennale.

Photo's by Daniel Rachamim: AAJ 2010 Fellow Lynne Avadenka's *Invention Tzadik*; Andi Arnovitz' *What We Bring*, in which she upcycled her wedding dress to serve as the vessel from which 2611 names burst forth: Jewish women whose achievements

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constitute our shared cultural assets; Linda Lief Altabet's parokhet *The Lifted Veil*
Not shown, Beryl Korot's incredible video *Ety*

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A seder table set for all the hostages at Hostage Square in front of the Tel Aviv Museum.

Here's some reading I've found useful over the last few weeks:

<https://www.nytimes.com/2024/04/16/arts/design/israel-pavilion-venice-biennale.html>

[Beth Steinberg's substack](#)

Times of Israel, about the risks of Israelis ignoring the tragedy in [Gaza](#)

[Protest mobs at UC Berkely truly are anti-semitic](#)

Matti Friedman's [excellent piece](#) : "The truth is that there isn't an "Israeli-Palestinian" conflict that exists in isolation... These days, the relevant conflict is between the alliance led by the Shia clerics of Iran's Islamic Republic against states in the American orbit, most of them Sunni, like Jordan and Saudi Arabia, and one of them Jewish."

A possible way forward: [A LAND FOR ALL](#)

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